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Men's Words, Women's Work: Exploring the Reverse Gender Gap in Post-2022 Russian Emigration

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Abstract

Are men truly more engaged in politics or do they just talk a good game? Since February 2022, over a million Russians have fled political repression, and among them, a surge in female activism has emerged, challenging traditional gender roles. Despite having fewer resources than men, Russian women are more politically and civically active abroad. This “reverse gender gap” has been marked in interviews with exiled activists and consistently observed in the OutRush survey. Traditional predictors of political participation do not fully explain this gap, which seems to be driven by war-induced emotions. I demonstrate that efforts and rewards are unfairly distributed between the genders: while women engage in intellectual work, they are, *inter alia*, disproportionately burdened with emotional labor, as well as the “domestic” and invisible tasks within the movements, whereas men focus primarily on high-visibility roles.

Since February 2022, over a million Russians have fled political dissatisfaction, fear, and repression, forming part of a broader trend of crisis-induced migration. These well-educated, urbanized, resourceful migrants with gender-egalitarian attitudes are politically and civically engaged (OutRush 2024). Despite their displacement, many continue their activism, co-opting local populations and authorities to alter the situation in their homeland from abroad.

Among these emigrants, a surge in female activism has emerged, challenging traditional gender roles in politics. Russian emigrants have formed various grassroots initiatives within Russia and globally, including aid organizations and anti-war groups. The rise of women in these political and social movements has been particularly notable, especially with the emergence of the Feminist Anti-War Resistance (FAR).

The collected data indicate that women's activism is accompanied by high costs and requires more resources than that of their male counterparts. Inequalities in activism between the sexes are the product of entrenched patriarchal stereotypes and reflect the consequences of gender socialization within Russian society.

Theoretically, women's greater vulnerability and the barriers they face in the political sphere should reduce their activism. However, OutRush data show that Russian women emigrants are more politically and civically active in almost all types of measured anti-war and civic activism. This phenomenon, known as the “reverse gender gap,” is observed in all three waves of the panel survey, confirming the significant role of women in both the political and civic spheres.

In the final section, I argue that one reason for the rise in women's activism is war-induced emotions, which

are felt and channeled differently by men and women. Using OutRush data and a series of interviews with FAR activists abroad, this paper analyzes the differences between male and female activism among Russian emigrants and explores the reasons behind the reverse gender gap.

Gendered Activism During Wartime

The reverse gender gap in political participation, being a relatively new phenomenon, is under-researched. However, it has sparked debate as to whether women are more politically active than men in certain cases and what factors influence their engagement. Classic studies on political participation stress that political activism has been dominated by men, with women voting less (Almond and Verba 1963), showing less interest in political parties (Bennett and Bennett 1989), and generally being less politically active. Moreover, researchers highlight the quite consistent findings that women have less political knowledge (Dassonneville and McAllister 2018), ambition (Fox and Lawless 2014), and public support in this arena (Verba, Nie, and Kim 1978).

As feminism and women's suffrage spread, the gender gap started to diminish, especially in some political areas. Some contemporary research uses both quantitative and qualitative data to explore this phenomenon, considering a variety of factors, such as age, types of activism or forms of participation. Qualitative data, in particular, provide deeper insights into the reasons for the gender gap.

For example, FAR activists argue that women are a driving force in activism, especially visible in volunteering. However, patriarchal structures and gender socialization often render their work invisible and their voices unheard. Anti-war feminist organizations during

the war exemplify gendered activism. Political crises and catastrophes, like war, cause societal changes, including shifts in gender roles, which often place additional burdens of responsibility and emotional labor on women.

Below, I will explore the qualitative differences in male and female activism according to FAR activists.

Differences in Difficulties: Qualitative Insights into Gendered Challenges in Activism

FAR participants highlight three key differences between male and female activism: agenda, risks and resources, and gender-based role allocation.

Agenda: Participants noted that gender socialization makes women more attuned to issues like domestic violence and professional inequality. These structural inequalities shape their activism. One activist explains, “It takes a long time to explain to men that for a woman to share her experience of violence, she must first endure it, process it, then verbalize it, and finally face condemnation and doubt” (QRIH011).

Risks and resources: Due to different privilege sets, women often need more resources to sustain activism and face higher risks. Women frequently bear a triple burden: regular work, family responsibilities and housework, and activism accompanied by personal challenges in emigration. Although it might seem that anti-war activism is less risky for women because authoritarian states are more lenient toward them, the reality is ambiguous. Almost all participants agree that women generally feel less safe, and this insecurity extends to the political sphere. Women may be more fearful at rallies or in police custody due to potential harassment and threats of violence, including rape and psychological abuse.

A male activist admits, “Of course, women’s experience of activism is worse, with additional barriers and problems from society and even colleagues. If a regular activist has a shot leg, women activists often have two shot legs and a weight attached to them. But most men in leadership don’t realize this. In all the communities I’ve been involved in, women have always been the main driving force” (DNIH014).

Gender-based role allocation: Not infrequently, gender roles are clearly assigned in social movements: women do the “domestic” and emotional work within the organization, while men take leadership positions, engage in intellectual work, and handle planning and representation. Thus, women are less visible in protest and political movements, often doing invisible but crucial work, while men become the public face of the movement. This is linked to gender roles and the perception of women in politics. Activists note that women are often not taken seriously and their voices receive less attention and credibility. Even in feminist movements, a charismatic male

figure is seen as more authoritative, while women face high barriers to entering politics and leadership positions.

For FAR participants, women’s activism often stems from daily life and addresses real issues they face, making them more empathetic and willing to work without expecting success. They suggest that for men, meanwhile, observing the results of their work may be more important in motivating them to continue it. As a consequence, women’s activism is often overshadowed by male figures, although in many cases it is women who are doing the lion’s share of the work to sustain the movement, both materially and emotionally.

It’s often easier for women to work without hope of success. I don’t know, maybe it has to do with female gender socialization, when you wash dishes every day, and you realize that tomorrow you will wash dishes, always you will wash dishes and nothing will ever change. A lot of women, they just do every day, there’s helping one family, second family, third family, one ticket, second ticket, without expecting the world to change tomorrow. And I’ve heard from women that they say, “Men often say, ‘You do your volunteering, and I’ll go write a strategy’” (QHIH027).

This inequitable division of labor and recognition is criticized by feminists. The public views politics as male-dominated due to patriarchy and prevailing stereotypes that elevate the visibility of men. Figuratively speaking, men do activism with their heads; women do it with their hands. While men do the words, women do the work. This is particularly significant given women’s greater vulnerability in life, exile, and activism.

Listen, women do more of the work; men do most of the words (RDIH005).

The Reverse Gender Gap: Quantitative Evidence

The theoretical assumption that women are less interested in politics is not supported by the OutRush data. There are no statistically significant gender differences in political interest. Across all three survey waves, 91% of women and 91% of men reported a high interest in Russian politics. Additionally, 67% of women and 64% of men are interested in the politics of their host country, and 50% of women and 51% of men talk about political issues often or all the time.

While interviews show that women are not necessarily less active but simply less visible, *quantitative data suggest that they are indeed more engaged*. In March 2022, OutRush data showed women were 7.3% more likely than men to engage in digital activism, 5.2% more

likely to protest, and 3% more likely to financially support initiatives in Russia. Women were also 13% more likely to help Ukrainian refugees, 3% more likely to volunteer (rising to 8.5% in September 2022), 1.9% more likely to support host country initiatives, and 4.1% more likely to assist fellow Russian emigrants. Despite the narrowing reverse gender gap over time, women's political and civic activism remains significantly higher than men's (see Figures 1 and 2 on p. 17).

Figures 1 and 2 illustrate the overall decline in activism over time among both genders and the narrowing of the reverse gender gap. In the next section, I will explain the reasons for these dynamics.

Unpacking the Drivers of Female Activism in Emigration

While women's significant involvement in political and civic activism is well-documented, the reasons behind this, particularly in migration contexts, require further exploration. Scholars highlight (see, for example, Martiniello 2005) various macro, meso, and individual factors influencing emigrant political participation. These include political beliefs, past political involvement, "institutional completeness" within immigrant communities, perceptions of residency status, feelings of belonging, understanding of political systems, and social capital. Traditional determinants like education, linguistic skills, socio-economic status, gender, age, and generational cohort might also play influential roles. Our analysis shows that the contribution of most of these variables to the gap is not that significant. Therefore, I focus on other factors, namely emotions caused by the war and subsequent emigration, which are often overlooked in studies of the gender gap.

War and subsequent exile have profound emotional impacts, and emotions are key catalysts of activism in social movement studies. Studies show (see, for example, Aroian, Norris, and Chiang 2003) that women are generally more vulnerable than men and, in emigration, are more prone to high levels of distress. Indeed, according to an OutRush survey conducted in the summer of 2023, women were 12% more likely to feel sad and 7% more likely to feel lonely than men (OutRush 2024). It is known that distress has a negative impact on subjective well-being, and theoretically, the worse a person's mental state is, the fewer emotional resources he or she has for activism. However, the case of Russian emigrant women shows that although distress may affect their activism negatively, it is not a determining factor. Despite their poorer emotional state, women are still more active, which allows us to assume the presence of some other significant catalysts for their activism.

In addition to the hardships of emigration, the realities of war bring about death and loss, with women mourning their sons, husbands, and grandsons. These

tragedies evoke a spectrum of emotions, from guilt and responsibility for the conflict's initiation to a longing for amends, alongside profound grief, suffering, and empathy for those affected. While some emotions (like grief, guilt, and depression) are passive, others (like rage, hatred, and a desire for justice) might lead to political action.

In September 2022, OutRush data showed that 55% of women felt guilty about starting the war compared to 48% of men (see Figure 3 on p. 18). Additionally, 64% of women and 57% of men felt responsible for the conflict. When it came to making amends for Russia's activities in Ukraine, 78% of women wanted to do so, compared to only 65% of men. Thus, war-induced emotions like guilt and compassion make women more prone to sympathize with victims and those affected by the conflict. This increased sensitivity to the human costs of war leads to a lower likelihood of endorsing military actions and a higher likelihood of participating in anti-war activism.

Although there are many predictors of political participation, war-induced emotions appear to be one of the main reasons for increased female activism among Russian migrants after February 2022. Being more vulnerable, women are more likely to empathize with the victims of war and to suffer from emotional burnout. The narrowing of the reverse gender gap in political and civic activism over time could be related to a reduction in the intensity and normalization of war experiences, as well as emotional burnout, which many female activists reported.

Conclusion

This paper has explored the dynamics of the reverse gender gap in political and civic activism among Russian emigrants after the invasion of Ukraine in February 2022, highlighting the quantitative and qualitative differences between male and female activism. Contrary to theoretical expectations, OutRush data reveal that Russian women in exile are more politically and civically active than their male counterparts. This increased engagement among female activists may be driven by war-induced emotions such as guilt, responsibility, and a desire for reparation.

The interviews with FAR activists further show that despite women's significant contributions to activism, they face greater risks, responsibilities, and systemic invisibility due to patriarchal structures and gender socialization. These challenges highlight the need for more support and recognition of women's roles in social movements. While acknowledging the significant contribution of Russian men to anti-war efforts in exile, this article underscores the fundamental role women play in shaping political landscapes and highlights the greater barriers they face in their activism.

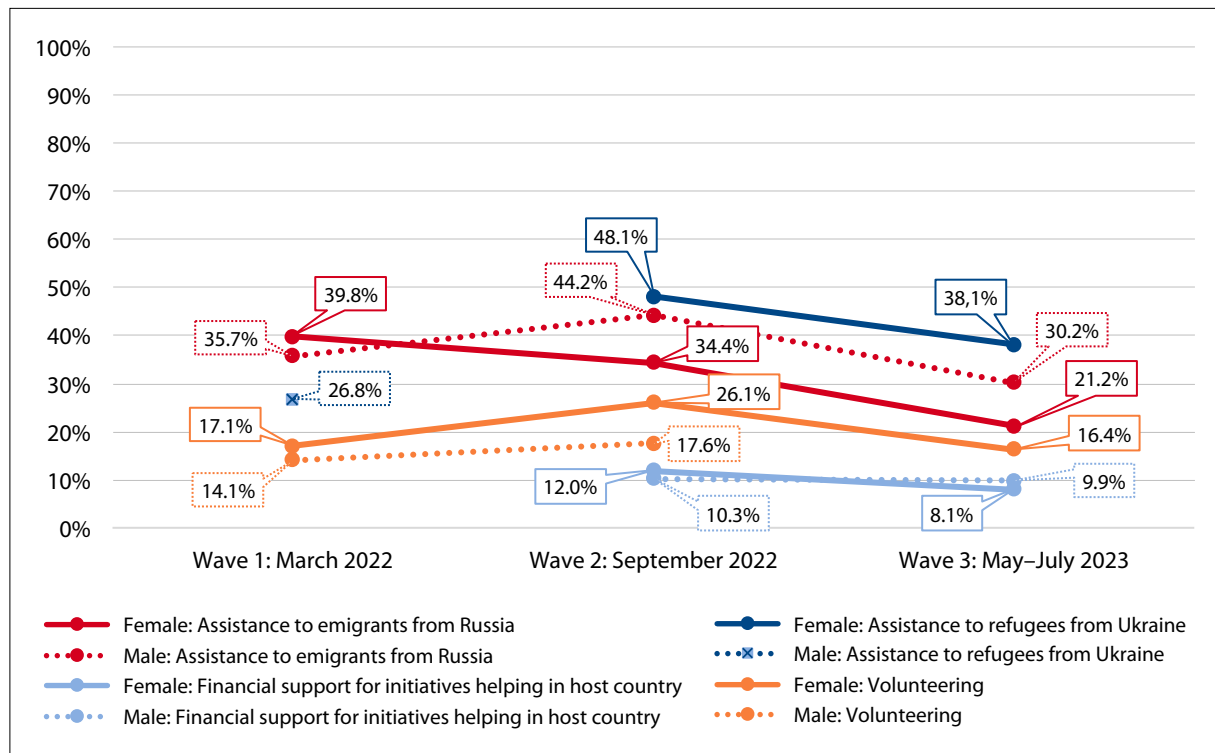
Please see overleaf for information about the author and further reading.

About the Author

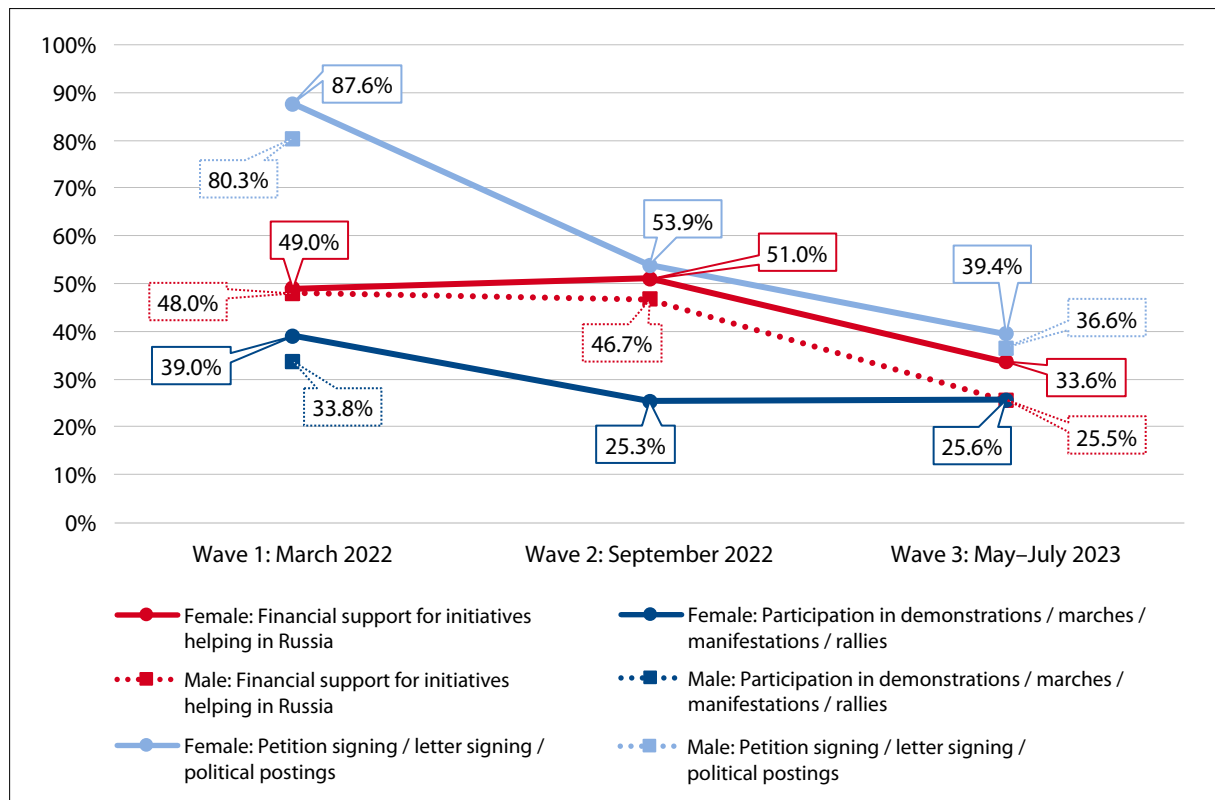
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Further Reading

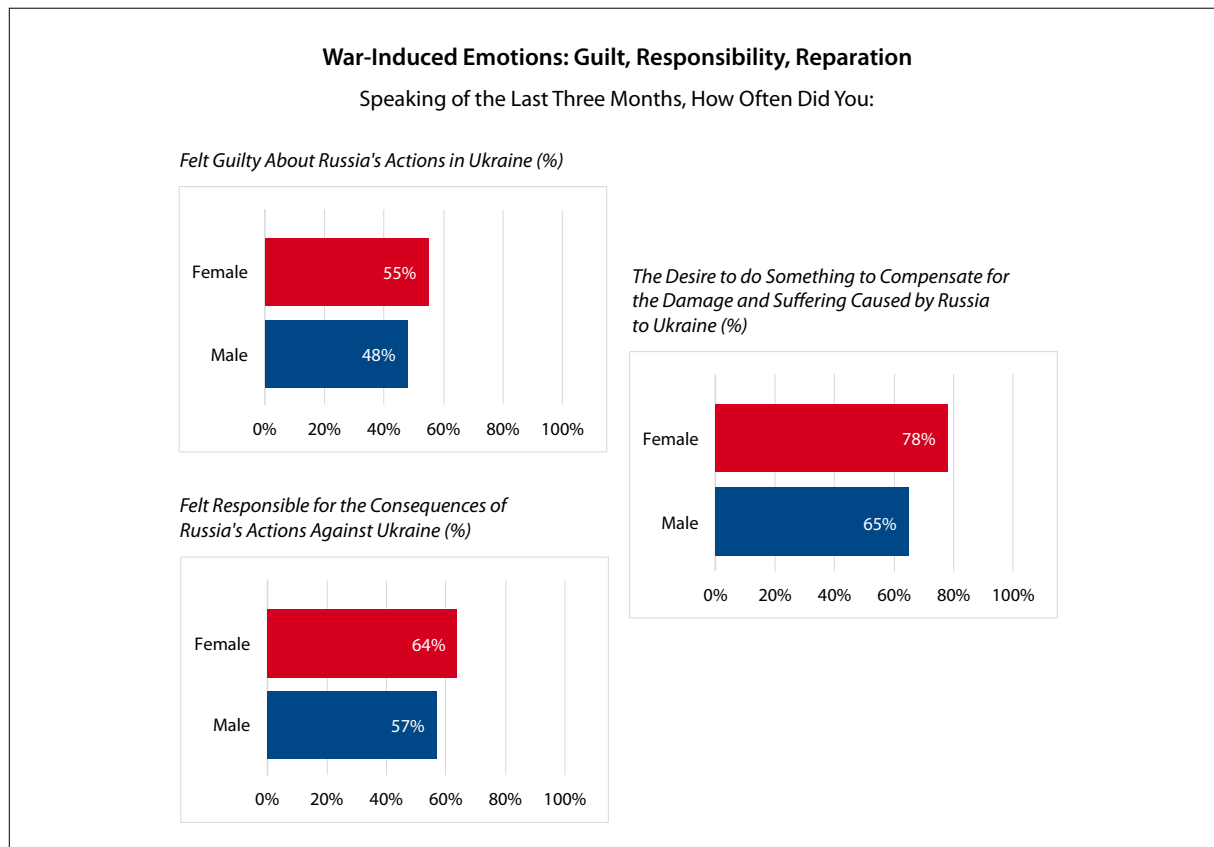
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Figure 1: Gender Differences in Civic Activism among Russian Emigrants, 2022–2023

Source: Three Waves of OutRush Survey (<https://outrush.io/eng>): Wave 1: March 2022, Wave 2: September 2022, Wave 3: May–July 2023; N unique: 465

Figure 2: Gender Differences in Civic Activism among Russian Emigrants, 2022–2023 (Continued)

Source: Three Waves of OutRush Survey (<https://outrush.io/eng>): Wave 1: March 2022, Wave 2: September 2022, Wave 3: May–July 2023; N unique: 465

Figure 3: Gendered Aspects of War-Induced Emotions

Source: OutRush Survey (<https://outrush.io/eng>), Wave 2: September 2022